7. To undertake and promote research in the field of human rights.

8. To spread human rights literacy among the people and promote awareness of the safeguards available for the protection of these rights.

9. To encourage the efforts of non-governmental organisations (NGOs) working in the field of human rights.

10. To undertake such other functions as it may consider necessary for the promotion of human rights.

In pursuit of its primary goal of protection and promotion of human rights, the commission has been making concerted efforts at enhancing awareness about human rights in the country. In this task, the commission has been receiving full support both from civil society/NGOs/human rights activists and the media. The camp sittings and open hearings organized by the commission in different parts of the country, to provide justice at the doorsteps of the victims of the human rights violations have proved to be of immensely useful.*2a*

The complaints received by the commission cover a wide range of issues such as alleged human rights violations due to negligence by public servants in the prevention of such violations, alleged custodial deaths, torture, fake encounters, police highhandedness, violations committed by security forces, conditions relating to prisons, atrocities committed on women and children and other vulnerable sections, communal violence, bonded and child labour, non-payment of retiral benefits, negligence by public authorities and atrocities on Scheduled Castes/Scheduled Tribes etc. The commission also took cognizance of the intimations received regarding deaths in police encounters and police custody, judicial custody and in the custody of defence/paramilitary forces. The suo motu cognizance of many incidents based on reports in print and electronic media was taken including those cases which came to the notice of Chairperson, Members, Special Rapporteurs and senior officers of the commission during their visits to different parts of the country.[2b]

Working

The commission's headquarters is in Delhi and it can also establish offices in other places in India. It is vested with the power to regulate its own procedure. It has all the powers of a civil court and its proceedings have a judicial character. It may call for information or report from the Central and state governments or any other authority subordinate thereto.

The commission has its own nucleus of investigating staff for investigation into complaints of human rights violations. Besides, it is empowered to utilise the services of any officer or investigation agency of the Central government or any state government for the purpose. It has also established effective cooperation with the NGOs with first-hand information about human rights violations.

The commission is not empowered to inquire into any matter after the expiry of one year from the date on which the act constituting violation of human rights is alleged to have been committed. In other words, it can look into a matter within one year of its occurrence.

The commission may take any of the following steps during or upon the completion of an inquiry:

1. it may recommend to the concerned government or authority to make payment of compensation or damages to the victim;